world could be. She calls me James, not Jimmy. She is not as interested in Jimmy as other people are. It's the first time in my adult life I think that maybe James has as much to give as Jimmy.

In our teens, scrambling around those bars in Burnley, dyeing each other's hair and running out of the back of pubs, me, Gaz and Dave used to say to each other, when another dead end had been reached, 'I don't think our wives are in Burnley.' I was never completely sure if we were joking or not. Daniella, though, is turning what are usually painstaking decisions into simple choices, as if it's the most natural thing to do in the world. It's all unthinking, uncomplicated forward momentum. There is something under the surface happening and beneath every conversation is newness, an ocean of understanding. We are connecting because we are both seeing similar things in each other and filling in the spaces where the other one feels a part of themselves is missing; a kind of dovetailing that is clarifying who we have been, who we are and who we'd like to be.

Daniella is from the Isle of Man, where she and her older brother were brought up in idyllic surroundings. She was not dug into her surroundings like Burnley and had the countryside, beaches and horses as part of her daily world. When they moved for her dad's work to Monmouth in Wales, when she was 11, they inhabited similarly beautiful, rural environments. Her brother, Nick, two years her senior, was her idol. Everything he did, she wanted to do. Nick was very good at sport too – playing cricket and representing England at rugby at under-21 level. They were very close and collectively very happy. When he was celebrating finishing his A levels, he put his head out of a moving car and hit a telegraph pole. She was called from her friend's house to the hospital, where a life support system was trying to keep him alive. While she was at the hospital, he died at 18 years old. He never got his A level results.

The next ten years of her life, between then and now, she has become a successful model. A window opens immediately between us, where we can talk about her brother, and she tells me she is struck by how comfortable she is talking to me about this and feels like she is not being judged. I know that I cannot fix what she is telling me, but I can listen. I'm looking at her as she speaks, awestruck by how well she has done in her life, and suddenly reflect on how lucky I have been. She describes the period after Nick's death as like dealing with snakebite – it not being the bite that kills you, but